A Beginner's Guide to Sourdough Bread

What is sourdough?

Sourdough is bread that rises with a starter instead of packaged yeast. A starter is a living mix of flour and water that holds wild yeast and friendly bacteria. The bacteria give the loaf its tangy flavour and help it stay fresh for longer.

Making a starter

A new starter takes about seven days to become active. Mix 50 grams of whole wheat flour with 50 grams of lukewarm water in a clean jar. Cover it loosely and keep it at room temperature, ideally between 24 and 27 degrees Celsius.

Every day, throw away half of the mixture and feed the rest with 50 grams of flour and 50 grams of water. By day five or six the starter should double in size within six hours of feeding and smell pleasantly sour, like yogurt. A starter that smells like nail polish is hungry and needs feeding more often.

Once the starter is strong, keep it in the fridge and feed it once a week. Take it out and feed it twice before you bake so that it is lively.

Ingredients

This recipe makes one loaf. You need 500 grams of bread flour, 350 grams of water, 100 grams of active starter and 10 grams of salt. The water is 70 percent of the flour weight, which gives a soft dough that is still easy to shape.

Choosing flour

Bread flour has more protein, usually 12 to 13 percent, so it gives a chewier loaf with a tall rise. All-purpose flour also works, but the dough has less structure. Whole wheat flour soaks up more water, so add 20 to 30 grams of extra water when you use it.

Use filtered water, or leave tap water in an open jug for an hour if it is heavily chlorinated, because too much chlorine can slow the starter down.

Equipment

You will need a digital scale, a large mixing bowl, a bench scraper and a basket or bowl lined with a floured towel for the final rise. A Dutch oven with a lid gives the best crust because it traps steam. You also need a sharp blade for scoring and a wire rack for cooling.

Mixing and resting

Stir the flour and water together first and let the shaggy mix rest for 30 minutes. This rest is called the autolyse, and it makes the dough smoother and easier to stretch. Then add the starter and the salt and mix by hand until there is no dry flour left.

Bulk fermentation

Cover the bowl and leave the dough at room temperature for 4 to 6 hours. During the first two hours, do a set of stretch and folds every 30 minutes, four sets in total. The dough is ready when it has grown by about 50 percent, looks airy and jiggles when you shake the bowl.

In a cold kitchen below 20 degrees Celsius the same step can take 8 to 10 hours, so judge the dough rather than the clock.

Shaping and the final proof

Tip the dough onto a lightly floured surface and fold it into a loose round. Rest it for 20 minutes, then shape it into a tight ball and place it seam side up in the basket. Cover it and put it in the refrigerator for 12 to 16 hours. This cold proof builds flavour and makes the dough firm enough to score cleanly.

Baking

Put the Dutch oven in the oven and preheat to 250 degrees Celsius for 45 minutes. Turn the dough out onto baking paper and score the top about 1 centimetre deep with a sharp blade. Lower it into the hot pot and put the lid on.

Bake covered for 20 minutes at 250 degrees Celsius. Then take the lid off, reduce the heat to 220 degrees and bake for another 20 to 25 minutes until the crust is deep golden brown. The inside of the loaf should reach at least 96 degrees Celsius.

Move the bread to a wire rack and let it cool for at least one hour before slicing. Cutting too early makes the crumb gummy.

Troubleshooting

A dense loaf with few holes usually means the starter was not active enough or the dough did not rise for long enough. A flat loaf that spreads sideways was probably over-proofed or too wet. A pale crust needs a longer bake with the lid off. If the taste is too sour, shorten the cold proof or feed the starter more often.

Storing your bread

Keep the loaf cut side down on a board for up to two days. For longer storage, slice it and freeze it for up to three months.